

**MEASURING SPIRITUAL MATURITY IN HEARING GOD:
AN AFFECTIVE DOMAIN TAXONOMY FOR
INDIVIDUAL, GROUP, AND INSTITUTIONAL INTERNALIZATION**

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Introduction: The Measurement Problem

Churches want to know if they are making disciples. The instinct to measure is sound: as the axiom attributed to Peter Drucker states, “What gets measured, gets improved.”¹ Yet after three decades of proliferating assessment instruments, no consensus has emerged on how to measure spiritual maturity. The landscape is littered with tools—each grounded in different theological assumptions, each measuring different constructs, each failing in different ways—and no unifying framework has been proposed to explain why consensus has proven so elusive.

This paper argues that the failure to achieve consensus is not primarily a failure of research methodology but a failure of taxonomic clarity. Existing instruments conflate different levels of affective internalization, using the same instruments to measure surface-level behavioral compliance that were intended to capture deep character transformation. Using Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia’s Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain as a diagnostic framework,² this paper demonstrates that most instruments operate at only the first two levels of internalization (Receiving and Responding), while the theological construct of spiritual maturity requires measurement at the third through fifth levels (Valuing, Organization, and Characterization). Paul Bramer has observed that Christian education “has had a tendency to focus on cognitive knowledge acquisition” while “Christian formation much more deliberately brings in the affective domain.”³ This paper develops that observation into a systematic measurement framework.

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¹ Peter Drucker, quoted in Jacob Drucker, “You Are What You Measure,” *Forbes*, December 4, 2018.

² David R. Krathwohl, Benjamin S. Bloom, and Bertram B. Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook II: Affective Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1964).

³ Paul D. G. Bramer, “Christian Formation: Tweaking the Paradigm,” *Christian Education Journal*, Series 3, vol. 4, no. 2 (Fall 2007): 352–63.

The paper proceeds in three movements. First, it surveys the existing instrument landscape—including Natural Church Development, the REVEAL Spiritual Life Survey, the Discipleship Pathway Assessment, the Faith Maturity Scale, the Spiritual Assessment Inventory, and Fowler’s Stages of Faith and diagnoses each instrument through the affective domain taxonomy. Second, it proposes criteria for adequate measurement at each level of internalization and extends the taxonomy across five scales: the individual, the small group, the congregation, the denomination, and the universal church—what the Nicene Creed confesses as “one holy, catholic, and apostolic.” Third, it applies the complete framework to the specific challenge of hearing and obeying God, drawing on Reformed, evangelical, charismatic, and mystical theological traditions to demonstrate the taxonomy’s generative capacity across all views.

The thesis is this: no existing instrument can reliably distinguish between a person who performs spiritual behaviors out of social compliance and a person whose character has been transformed by the indwelling Spirit. Jesus identified this exact problem with the Pharisees: impeccable outward performance without interior transformation. Until measurement frameworks account for the full depth of affective internalization, consensus will remain impossible, and assessment results will remain misleading.

The Affective Domain and Spiritual Formation

In 1964, David Krathwohl, Benjamin Bloom, and Bertram Masia published the second volume of their landmark taxonomy of educational objectives, addressing the affective domain—the realm of attitudes, values, emotions, and motivations.⁴ While Bloom’s cognitive taxonomy achieved wide adoption,⁵ the affective taxonomy remained comparatively neglected. Yet it is the affective domain, not the cognitive, that most directly addresses the construct of spiritual maturity. Knowing the right answers (cognitive) is not the same as having the right values characterologically embedded (affective). The Pharisees scored perfectly on the cognitive domain; Jesus’ critique was entirely about their affective status.

The Five Levels of Internalization

Krathwohl’s taxonomy is ordered according to the principle of internalization, the process by which an external value progressively becomes an internal, governing characteristic of the person.⁶ The five levels, from lowest to highest, are:

Receiving. The person is aware of and willing to attend to certain ideas or phenomena. In spiritual terms, the person has heard the gospel, is exposed to Scripture, and is willing to listen. This is the floor of spiritual engagement.

Responding. The person actively engages, participates, complies, and follows through. They join a Bible study, complete assigned readings, and pray when prompted. Motivation is still largely external: social expectation, curriculum requirements, and accountability structures.

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⁴ David R. Krathwohl, Benjamin S. Bloom, and Bertram B. Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook II: Affective Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1964).

⁵ Benjamin S. Bloom et al., *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook I: Cognitive Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1956).

⁶ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 35–38.

Valuing. The person has internalized the value sufficiently to pursue it without external prompting. They read Scripture not because a study guide requires it but because they want to. They serve from conviction rather than obligation. The critical shift is from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation.

Organization. The person integrates the value into a coherent system, resolving conflicts between competing values and arranging priorities. Faith informs vocation, relationships, finances, and daily decisions—not compartmentally but systemically.

Characterization. The value has controlled behavior for a sufficiently long time that it has become a characteristic lifestyle, “pervasive, consistent, and predictable.”⁷ The person does not deliberate about whether to act on the value; it is who they are.

A complementary theoretical framework illuminates why this internalization sequence operates as it does. Transcendental Field Theory (TFT) models Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as interacting fields with coupling parameters that govern their mutual influence.⁸ In this framework, Krathwohl’s levels correspond to increasing coupling strength between the fields. At Level 1, the fields barely interact: the person is exposed to Truth (cognitive content) without engagement of Goodness (moral transformation) or Beauty (aesthetic attraction). At Level 2, external forces sustain the coupling, social expectation, curriculum, and accountability. At Level 3, the coupling becomes self-sustaining: Truth has become Beautiful to the person, and Goodness is pursued for its own sake. At Level 4, the fields form a coherent system, competing values are resolved because the field configuration has reached a stable attractor state. At Level

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⁷ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 165– 85. Krathwohl describes Characterization as behavior that is “pervasive, consistent, and predictable.”

⁸ The Transcendental Field Theory framework treats Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as interacting quantum fields with coupling parameters α , β , and γ , operating on a curved internal manifold. For the full formulation, see the appendix. The framework is heuristic rather than empirically quantified, functioning as a structural analogy for theological reflection.

5, the system has reached what TFT calls the Peace state: all fields are in equilibrium, behavior is pervasive and predictable because the person's character has become a stable minimum in the configuration space.⁹ This framework explains why spiritual maturity cannot be reduced to any single dimension, cognitive knowledge (Truth alone), behavioral compliance (Goodness alone), or experiential intensity (Beauty alone), and why instruments measuring only one field systematically fail to capture higher levels of internalization.

Biblical Warrant for Progressive Internalization

Scripture consistently presents spiritual maturity as a process of progressive internalization that maps naturally onto Krathwohl's levels. The author of Hebrews rebukes readers who should be teachers but still need milk: "For though by this time you ought to be teachers, you need someone to teach you again the basic principles of the oracles of God. You need milk, not solid food, for everyone who lives on milk is unskilled in the word of righteousness, since he is a child. But solid food is for the mature, for those who have their powers of discernment trained by constant practice to distinguish good from evil" (Heb 5:12–14 ESV). The progression from milk to solid food, from unskilled to trained, from child to mature, describes movement through levels of internalization.

Peter commands believers to "long for the pure spiritual milk, that by it you may grow up into salvation" (1 Pet 2:2). The longing itself—craving as an indicator of genuine valuing rather than mere compliance—marks the transition from Level 2 to Level 3. Paul describes transformation as progressive: "And we all, with unveiled face, beholding the glory of the Lord,

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⁹ In TFT terms, the eschatological Peace (Shalom) state corresponds to a stable minimum where all field time-derivatives vanish and the Hessian matrix is positive definite—the system has reached its maximum flourishing configuration and resists perturbation.

are being transformed into the same image from one degree of glory to another” (2 Cor 3:18).

The language of degrees suggests a continuum, not a binary.

Ephesians 4:11–16 describes the telos in explicitly characterological terms: the church is to “attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to mature manhood, to the measure of the stature of the fullness of Christ, so that we may no longer be children, tossed to and fro by the waves and carried about by every wind of doctrine” (Eph 4:13–14). Maturity here is stability of character Krathwohl’s Level 5, where behavior is “pervasive, consistent, and predictable.”¹⁰

The fruit of the Spirit (Gal 5:22–23)—love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control—is presented not as a list of behaviors to perform but as the natural produce of a life indwelt by the Spirit. Fruit grows organically from character; it cannot be manufactured. This is the essence of Level 5: the values have become so deeply embedded that their expression is spontaneous rather than deliberate.

The Parable of the Sower: Jesus’ Own Internalization Taxonomy

The Parable of the Sower (Matt 13:1–23; Mark 4:1–20; Luke 8:4–15) is perhaps the most precise biblical mapping of Krathwohl’s internalization levels, because Jesus explicitly diagnoses where and why the word fails to take root at each stage. The four soils are not descriptions of personality types; they are descriptions of internalization failure points. Jesus’ own interpretation identifies the exact affective level at which each soil’s reception breaks down.

The path represents a failure at Level 1 (Receiving). The seed falls but never penetrates the surface: “When anyone hears the word of the kingdom and does not understand it, the evil one comes and snatches away what has been sown in his heart” (Matt 13:19). The word is heard

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¹⁰ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 176–80.

but not received—there is no willingness to attend, no crack in the surface through which the seed can enter. The person sits in the pew, hears the sermon, and remains entirely unaffected. No instrument can measure what was never received. This is pre-Level 1: the precondition of openness has not been met.

The rocky ground represents a failure at the Level 2–3 transition (Responding without reaching Valuing). “As for what was sown on rocky ground, this is the one who hears the word and immediately receives it with joy, yet he has no root in himself, but endures only for a while, and when tribulation or persecution arises on account of the word, immediately he falls away” (Matt 13:20–21). The critical diagnostic is “no root in himself.” The person responds—with genuine enthusiasm—but the response is externally sustained rather than internally rooted. Joy is present, but it is the joy of novelty, social belonging, or emotional experience rather than the joy of a value that has become the person’s own. When the external supports are removed—when tribulation comes, when the small group dissolves, when the culture turns hostile—there is nothing internal to sustain the behavior. This is precisely the transition from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation that Krathwohl identifies as the move from Responding to Valuing. The rocky-ground hearer never makes that transition.

The thorny ground represents a failure at the Level 3–4 transition (Valuing without reaching Organization). “As for what was sown among thorns, this is the one who hears the word, but the cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches choke the word, and it proves unfruitful” (Matt 13:22). This is the most subtle failure because the word has genuinely taken root—the person has internalized it as a value. They are not pretending; they genuinely care about the kingdom. But they have not organized their value system such that the kingdom takes priority over competing values. The cares of the world and the deceitfulness of riches are not

external persecutions; they are internal competitors. The person values the word and values financial security and values social status, and when these values conflict, the word loses. This is compartmentalized Christianity—genuine faith that has not been integrated into a governing life system. Krathwohl’s Level 4 (Organization) requires exactly this integration: resolving conflicts between values and arranging them into a coherent hierarchy. The thorny-ground hearer has values but no hierarchy.

The good soil represents successful internalization through Levels 4–5 (Organization to Characterization). “As for what was sown on good soil, this is the one who hears the word and understands it. He indeed bears fruit and yields, in one case a hundredfold, in another sixty, and in another thirty” (Matt 13:23). Luke’s version adds a critical qualifier: the good soil represents those who “hearing the word, hold it fast in an honest and good heart, and bear fruit with patience” (Luke 8:15). Three elements define the good soil: the word is held fast (Organization—it has been integrated as a governing priority that competing values cannot dislodge), the heart is honest and good (the interior state matches the exterior behavior—no Pharisee gap), and fruit is borne with patience (Characterization—the values produce consistent, observable outcomes over time, not in a burst of enthusiasm but through sustained character). The varying yields—thirty, sixty, a hundredfold—suggest that even within Characterization there are degrees, consistent with Krathwohl’s description of Level 5 as a continuum rather than a fixed point.

The parable thus provides a diagnostic framework that complements Krathwohl’s taxonomy with theological specificity. Each soil identifies not only where internalization fails but why: the path fails because the heart is hard (no openness to receive); the rocky ground fails because the root system is shallow (no internal anchor for the value); the thorny ground fails

because the value system is unorganized (competing commitments choke growth); and the good soil succeeds because the word has been fully internalized into the character of the person. Any instrument that claims to measure spiritual maturity must be able to distinguish between these four conditions—and as the instrument survey will demonstrate, none currently can.

In TFT terms, the four soils describe four distinct field configurations. The path represents zero coupling—Truth arrives but engages neither Goodness nor Beauty; the seed has no field to couple with. The rocky ground represents unstable coupling: initial Beauty-coupling (the joy of novelty, the attraction of belonging) without Goodness-coupling (moral rootedness); when external perturbation arrives, the system has no stable minimum to return to. The thorny ground represents competing attractors in the configuration space—the word has genuinely coupled, but rival potentials (the cares of the world, the deceitfulness of riches) create local minima that trap the system short of the global attractor.¹¹ The good soil represents a stable trajectory toward Glory: all three fields coupled, the system moving through configuration space toward the eschatological maximum where Truth, Goodness, and Beauty achieve their fullest mutual expression.

The Pharisee Problem: Measuring Levels 1–2 While Assuming Levels 4–5

Jesus' sustained critique of the Pharisees is, at its core, a critique of measuring low-level behavioral compliance and mistaking it for high-level characterological transformation. “Woe to you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! For you clean the outside of the cup and the plate, but inside they are full of greed and self-indulgence” (Matt 23:25). The Pharisees scored perfectly on every Level 2 metric—attendance, tithing, prayer frequency, Scripture knowledge, public

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¹¹ Glory in TFT corresponds to the attractor state—the global maximum of combined field strength where Truth, Goodness, and Beauty achieve their fullest mutual expression. Glory is Beauty-at-eschatological-completion.

righteousness. Yet Jesus declared that tax collectors and prostitutes would enter the kingdom before them (Matt 21:31).

This is not merely a moral critique; it is a measurement critique. The Pharisees' error was assuming that behavioral compliance (Level 2) indicated characterological transformation (Level 5). Every existing spiritual maturity instrument risks the same error when it relies primarily on self-reported behavioral frequency. Jeremiah's declaration that "the heart is deceitful above all things, and desperately sick; who can understand it?" (Jer 17:9) is not just a proof-text; it is a genuine epistemological claim about the limits of introspective self-report. In TFT terms, the Pharisee problem is a field-decoupling problem: the Truth field (cognitive mastery of Scripture) and the behavioral surface of the Goodness field (public righteousness) were highly developed, but the coupling between them was absent—the knowledge had not transformed the character. Measuring Truth field strength alone, or even measuring behavioral outputs alone, cannot detect whether the fields are genuinely coupled. Only the fruit—the emergent product of all three fields interacting over time—reveals the true state of the system.

Existing Instruments Through the Affective Domain Lens

Six instruments warrant examination, spanning academic psychology and church practice. When analyzed through the affective domain taxonomy, a pattern emerges: instruments cluster at Levels 1–3, with no instrument reliably measuring Levels 4–5.

Natural Church Development (Schwarz)

Christian Schwarz’s Natural Church Development measures eight quality characteristics of healthy churches through a survey of thirty leadership members.¹² NCD operates at Level 1–2 of the affective domain. It measures organizational climate—whether leaders perceive the church as exhibiting empowering leadership, gift-based ministry, passionate spirituality, and similar characteristics—but it cannot assess whether individual members have internalized these values beyond participation. Critics have described the underlying research as “pseudo-science” built on survey methodology that lacks sufficient rigor.¹³ More fundamentally, NCD’s biological organism metaphor smuggles in ecclesiological assumptions while claiming theological neutrality.

REVEAL Spiritual Life Survey (Hawkins and Parkinson)

The REVEAL study, originating at Willow Creek Community Church, surveyed over 250,000 individuals across more than 1,000 churches, placing respondents on a four-stage spiritual continuum from “Exploring Christ” to “Christ-Centered.”¹⁴ REVEAL’s key finding—that church activity does not predict or drive long-term spiritual growth—is itself a demonstration of

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¹² Christian A. Schwarz, *Natural Church Development: A Guide to Eight Essential Qualities of Healthy Churches* (Carol Stream, IL: ChurchSmart Resources, 1996).

¹³ John Ellas and Flavil R. Yeakley, “Book Review: Natural Church Development by Christian Schwarz,” *Journal of the American Society for Church Growth* 10, no. 2 (1999): 83–92.

¹⁴ Hawkins and Parkinson, *Move*, 24–25. The 250,000 figure represents cumulative respondents across multiple rounds of data collection from 2007 to 2011.

the affective domain problem.¹⁵ Behavioral participation (Level 2) does not correlate with interior transformation (Levels 3–5). REVEAL operates at Levels 2–3, measuring self-reported spiritual practices and self-placed relational closeness to Christ. However, sociologist Bradley Wright criticized the study for using cross-sectional data to draw longitudinal conclusions—snapshots interpreted as trajectories.¹⁶ The Technical Report 3.0 acknowledged that respondents skewed married, higher income, more educated, and disproportionately White, suggesting significant self-selection bias.¹⁷

Discipleship Pathway Assessment (Waggoner/LifeWay)

The Discipleship Pathway Assessment, built on Brad Waggoner’s 1991 doctoral research and refined through a 28-member expert panel Delphi method from 2010 to 2012, measures eight “biblical signposts” through a sixty-eight-question self-report instrument.¹⁸ The DPA operates at Levels 2–3—measuring reported frequency of spiritual behaviors and self-assessed attitudes across categories including Bible engagement, obeying God, serving others, and sharing Christ.¹⁹ Vannoy’s 2023 study of churches using the DPA found that practitioners rated it moderately useful (3.92/5) but identified critical weaknesses.²⁰ One church leader noted that the assessment “could almost show the church member the desired answer and without even realizing it nudge them to answer in the way they think they should answer.”²¹ This is precisely the Level 2–3

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¹⁵ Hawkins and Parkinson, *Move*, 10.

¹⁶ Bradley Wright, review of *Reveal: Where Are You?*, by Greg L. Hawkins and Cally Parkinson, *Modern Reformation*, 2008.

¹⁷ Nancy Scammacca Lewis, “REVEAL Spiritual Life Survey Technical Report 3.0” (2012).

¹⁸ Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness,” 41–45. The Transformational Discipleship Assessment was developed through a Delphi method with a 28-member expert panel from 2010 to 2012, yielding 8 domains.

¹⁹ Eric Geiger, Michael Kelley, and Philip Nation, *Transformational Discipleship: How People Really Grow* (Nashville: B&H, 2012), 12–15.

²⁰ Chandler Keith Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness of the Discipleship Pathway Assessment in the Local Church” (DEdMin project, The Southern Baptist Theological Seminary, 2023), 64.

²¹ Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness,” 67.

indistinguishability problem: the instrument cannot differentiate between a person who genuinely values Bible engagement and one who merely knows the “right answer” on a survey.

Participation rates compound the problem; even Beulah Church, a congregation of 2,800, achieved only 11 percent participation in its best year.²²

Faith Maturity Scale (Benson, Donahue, and Erickson)

Developed at the Search Institute as part of the National Study of Protestant Congregations, the Faith Maturity Scale operationalizes faith as comprising vertical (relationship with God) and horizontal (commitment to serving others) dimensions, validated across 11,000 participants from six mainline and evangelical denominations.²³ The FMS is psychometrically stronger than the church-practice instruments, with validated factor structure across denominations. It operates primarily at Level 3—measuring self-reported value commitment—but remains constrained by its self-report methodology and its framing for mainline Protestant contexts.

Spiritual Assessment Inventory (Hall and Edwards)

The SAI is unique among these instruments in its attempt to measure relational quality with God through an object relations framework.²⁴ Its five factors—Awareness of God, Realistic Acceptance, Disappointment, Grandiosity, and Instability—operate at Levels 3–4, assessing not just behavioral frequency but the quality and maturity of the person’s relational orientation toward God. Critically, the SAI includes an Impression Management subscale designed to detect

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²² Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness,” 67. Beulah Church, with approximately 2,800 weekend attendees, achieved only 310 participants in year one (11 percent), declining to 150 by year three.

²³ Benson, Donahue, and Erickson, “Faith Maturity Scale,” 6–8. The study sampled 11,000 participants from six mainline and evangelical denominations: Christian Church (Disciples of Christ), Evangelical Lutheran Church in America, Presbyterian Church (USA), United Church of Christ, United Methodist Church, and Southern Baptist Convention.

²⁴ Todd W. Hall and Keith J. Edwards, “The Spiritual Assessment Inventory: A Theistic Model and Measure for Assessing Spiritual Development,” *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion* 41, no. 2 (2002): 341–57.

socially desirable responding—the only instrument in this survey that even attempts to address the self-report validity problem.²⁵ Its limitation is its grounding in psychoanalytic theory, which may not translate across all theological traditions.

Fowler's Stages of Faith

James Fowler's developmental stage model theoretically reaches the highest levels of internalization, with Stage 5 (Conjunctive Faith) and Stage 6 (Universalizing Faith) describing deeply characterological transformation.²⁶ However, Parker's review concluded that only the "broad contours" of the theory have adequate empirical support, the invariant stage sequence has not been validated longitudinally, and Stage 6 is essentially aspirational.²⁷ The primary measurement method—a lengthy clinical interview—is impractical for church use. Short-form scales lose the construct's complexity. The Kantian philosophical presuppositions embedded in the model further limit its usefulness for confessional Christian communities.

Summary: The Clustering Problem

When analyzed through the affective domain taxonomy, a clear pattern emerges. Hill and Pargament's observation that religion and spirituality are typically measured by "global indices that do not specify how or why religion and spirituality affect health" applies with equal force to spiritual maturity measurement.²⁸ The instruments cluster at Levels 2–3. None reliably measures Level 5 (Characterization). The only instrument that attempts to detect deception at lower levels

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²⁵ Hall and Edwards, "Spiritual Assessment Inventory," 349–51. The Impression Management subscale consists of items designed to identify respondents presenting an unrealistically positive spiritual self-image.

²⁶ Fowler, *Stages of Faith*, 197–211. Stage 5 (Conjunctive Faith) involves integration of opposites and openness to paradox; Stage 6 (Universalizing Faith) involves selfless devotion to transforming social conditions.

²⁷ Parker, "Research in Fowler's Faith Development Theory," 244–47. Parker notes that no published longitudinal study has tracked individuals through the predicted stage sequence.

²⁸ Peter C. Hill and Kenneth I. Pargament, "Advances in the Conceptualization and Measurement of Religion and Spirituality: Implications for Physical and Mental Health Research," *American Psychologist* 58, no. 1 (2003): 64–74.

is the SAI with its Impression Management subscale. This clustering is not coincidental; it reflects the fundamental methodological constraint of self-report instrumentation.

TFT provides a structural explanation for this clustering. Each instrument measures one or two fields in isolation: NCD and REVEAL measure behavioral outputs (surface Goodness), the FMS measures value commitment (deeper Goodness), the SAI measures relational quality (Goodness-Beauty coupling), and Fowler measures cognitive-developmental structure (Truth). But spiritual maturity at Levels 4–5 is an emergent property of all three fields coupled together—it cannot be decomposed into single-field measurements any more than the flavor of a meal can be captured by measuring each ingredient separately. The clustering at Levels 2–3 is precisely where single-field measurement reaches its ceiling; beyond this point, only the interaction effects between fields carry diagnostic information, and no existing instrument is designed to detect interaction effects.²⁹

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²⁹ The Transcendental Field Theory framework treats Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as interacting quantum fields with coupling parameters α , β , and γ , operating on a curved internal manifold. For the full formulation, see the appendix. The framework is heuristic rather than empirically quantified, functioning as a structural analogy for theological reflection.

Why Higher Levels Resist Self-Report Measurement

Four structural problems explain why Levels 3–5 resist conventional self-report methodology.

The Indistinguishability Problem

Levels 2 and 5 produce identical behavioral outputs. The person who serves out of social expectation and the person who serves from transformed character both report “I serve regularly.” A person performing spiritual behaviors out of compliance (Level 2) and a person whose character has been transformed (Level 5) will generate identical scores on any instrument that measures behavioral frequency. This is the fundamental measurement wall.

The Self-Knowledge Problem

Genuine Characterization (Level 5) may be less self-aware than lower levels because the value has become automatic. The most spiritually mature person may actually underreport because their behavior feels unremarkable to them. Conversely, someone at Level 2 may overreport because they are performing for an audience—including themselves. This creates a parallel to Kruger and Dunning’s finding that those least competent are most confident in their self-assessment.³⁰ In the spiritual domain, those most mature are most aware of their deficiency. Paul near the end of his life declared, “Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners, of whom I am the foremost” (1 Tim 1:15)—present tense, not past.

The Theological Problem

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³⁰ Justin Kruger and David Dunning, “Unskilled and Unaware of It: How Difficulties in Recognizing One’s Own Incompetence Lead to Inflated Self-Assessments,” *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology* 77, no. 6 (1999): 1121–34.

Jeremiah 17:9 is not merely a proof-text but a genuine epistemological claim about the limits of introspection. If the heart is opaque even to its owner, self-report instruments are measuring the person's theory about themselves, not their actual interior state. Samuel's experience selecting David confirms this: "The LORD sees not as man sees: man looks on the outward appearance, but the LORD looks on the heart" (1 Sam 16:7). If even a prophet cannot assess interior spiritual states by observation, the prospects for a Likert-scale survey are dim.

TFT provides a structural account of why the heart resists measurement. The Fall injected disorder into the field configuration, disrupting the coupling between Truth, Goodness, and Beauty.³¹ In the disordered state, a person can hold true beliefs (Truth field intact) while acting against them (Goodness field decoupled), and can perceive beauty in what is harmful (Beauty field distorted). The heart's deceitfulness is not random noise but systematic field decoupling: the person's self-assessment draws on whichever field is locally strongest, not on the true coupling state of all three. A person with strong Truth field strength genuinely believes they are spiritually mature because their doctrinal knowledge is excellent—they cannot see what the survey cannot see: that the knowledge has not coupled to their character. The opacity of the heart is, in field terms, the opacity of coupling states to single-field measurement.

The Participation Problem

An instrument's theoretical validity is irrelevant if populations will not complete it. Vannoy's data on the DPA showed declining participation even among enthusiastic early adopters, with the suggested next steps scoring lowest in perceived usefulness (3.69/5).³² The assessment itself can

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³¹ TFT models the Fall as the injection of disorder into the field configuration, disrupting the coupling between Truth, Goodness, and Beauty. The background manifold is corrupted, stable minima are displaced, and the system's natural trajectory tends toward fragmentation rather than Glory.

³² Vannoy, "Measuring the Usefulness," 72.

be statistically validated, but if churches cannot achieve participation rates above a meaningful threshold, the results will be skewed by self-selection bias toward the most engaged members—precisely the population least in need of assessment.

Proposed Criteria for Measurement at Each Affective Level

Rather than proposing a single replacement instrument, this paper proposes level-specific criteria for what adequate measurement would require at each stage of internalization.

Levels 1–2: Receiving and Responding

Conventional metrics work at these levels. Attendance, participation frequency, completion of assigned readings, group attendance, and giving records are adequate because the behaviors are external and verifiable. Self-report is sufficient because the construct being measured (behavioral participation) matches the method (behavioral self-report). Churches already measure these levels well. The problem is not measurement failure at Levels 1–2 but the assumption that these metrics indicate transformation at Levels 3–5.

Level 3: Valuing

Measurement at Level 3 requires motivation-sensitive items—not “Do you read the Bible?” but “When you miss Bible reading for a week, what do you experience?” Reverse-scored items become critical, as do impression management subscales following the SAI model. Behavioral consistency checks—whether reported values match across different life domains—can help distinguish genuine valuing from socially conditioned reporting. The most reliable indicator of genuine Level 3 is what the person does when no one is watching and nothing is required.

Level 4: Organization

Measurement at Level 4 requires scenario-based assessment—presenting value conflicts and asking how the person resolves them. Not “Do you value generosity?” but “When generosity conflicts with financial security for your family, how do you navigate that?” This moves beyond the SAI’s relational quality approach toward concrete dilemmas. Multi-source data becomes

essential: does the person's self-report match what their small group leader, spouse, or coworker would say?

Level 5: Characterization

Level 5 may be fundamentally unmeasurable by the individual alone. Krathwohl described this level as requiring observation of behavior that is “pervasive, consistent, and predictable” over time.³³ The theological parallel is that fruit is observed by others, not self-certified: “You will recognize them by their fruits” (Matt 7:16). Measurement at this level requires longitudinal pastoral observation, community corroboration, and behavioral consistency across contexts. A complete instrument for spiritual maturity would need to be a multi-method, longitudinal, multi-source assessment system, not a single survey.

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³³ Krathwohl, Bloom, and Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: Affective Domain*, 165– 85. Krathwohl describes Characterization as behavior that is “pervasive, consistent, and predictable.”

Hearing and Obeying God: The Individual Taxonomy Applied

To demonstrate the taxonomy's generative capacity, this section applies it to a specific domain of spiritual maturity: hearing and obeying God. Four theological traditions—reformed, evangelical, charismatic, and mystical—each contribute irreplaceable insights at different levels. No tradition alone can move a person from Level 1 to Level 5.

Level 1: Receiving—Awareness That God Speaks

At this level, the person becomes aware that God communicates and is willing to attend to that reality. The reformed tradition anchors this in the sufficiency of Scripture: “All Scripture is breathed out by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, and for training in righteousness” (2 Tim 3:16). The evangelical tradition emphasizes proclamation: “So faith comes from hearing, and hearing through the word of Christ” (Rom 10:17). The charismatic tradition insists that the Spirit is active and communicative now, not only in the historical text (Acts 2:17). The mystical tradition speaks of awakening—a first stirring of awareness that there is a deeper reality: “Be still, and know that I am God” (Ps 46:10). Most churches do Level 1 well through preaching, worship, and evangelism. The danger is assuming that receiving equals transformation.

Level 2: Responding—Active Engagement

The person engages with the means of grace—regular Bible reading, prayer, corporate worship.³⁴ The evangelical “quiet time” tradition anchors this: “Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path” (Ps 119:105). The charismatic tradition adds the practice of listening

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³⁴ John Calvin, *Institutes of the Christian Religion*, ed. John T. McNeill, trans. Ford Lewis Battles, Library of Christian Classics 20–21 (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1960), III.2.6.

prayer—bringing specific questions to God and attending to impressions. The mystical tradition contributes deliberate contemplative practice: lectio divina, centering prayer, the examen. At Level 2, these practices often feel mechanical. The person is doing the practices but has not yet experienced the deep interior shift they aim to produce. This is where most discipleship programs operate and where most assessment instruments measure.

Level 3: Valuing—Internalization of Desire

Engagement shifts from discipline to desire. The reformed tradition calls this the “sense of the heart”—Jonathan Edwards’s term for spiritual perception that finds the truth not merely correct but beautiful and compelling.³⁵ “Oh how I love your law! It is my meditation all the day” (Ps 119:97). The evangelical tradition describes this as the Bible becoming personal—“When I found your words, I ate them, and your words became to me a joy and the delight of my heart” (Jer 15:16). The charismatic contribution is the development of discernment—learning to distinguish the Spirit’s voice from one’s own thoughts (1 John 4:1). The mystical tradition describes the transition from meditation (active, effortful) to contemplation (receptive, gift-like): “One thing have I asked of the LORD, that will I seek after” (Ps 27:4). This is where the self-report problem becomes acute: a person at Level 2 who has been in Christian community long enough knows they should describe their spiritual life in Level 3 language.

Level 4: Organization—Integrated Discernment

The person organizes their entire life around hearing and obeying God. The reformed emphasis on worldview and lordship becomes operationally real: “Whether you eat or drink, or whatever

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³⁵ Edwards, *Religious Affections*, 96–100. Edwards distinguishes “notional understanding” from the “sense of the heart”—a direct, experiential perception of divine beauty that transforms the affections.

you do, do all to the glory of God” (1 Cor 10:31).³⁶ The evangelical tradition contributes a mature decision-making framework integrating Scripture, prayer, wise counsel, and circumstances: “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and do not lean on your own understanding” (Prov 3:5–6).³⁷ The charismatic tradition describes collaborative life with God—ongoing dialogue where the Spirit’s leading and human agency are woven together: “For all who are led by the Spirit of God are sons of God” (Rom 8:14). The mystical tradition contributes the dark night of the senses—God withdrawing felt consolations so the person can hear and obey from a deeper place than feeling.³⁸ “Though the fig tree should not blossom, nor fruit be on the vines ... yet I will rejoice in the LORD” (Hab 3:17–18).

Level 5: Characterization—God’s Voice as Default Orientation

Hearing and obeying God is no longer something the person does; it is who they are. Paul’s language is precise: “I have been crucified with Christ. It is no longer I who live, but Christ who lives in me” (Gal 2:20). The reformed tradition recognizes this as perseverance of the saints experienced from the inside. The evangelical tradition sees the person’s life as a “living testimony”: “You will recognize them by their fruits” (Matt 7:16). The charismatic tradition describes spiritual gifts operating intuitively rather than effortfully: “The Helper, the Holy Spirit ... will teach you all things” (John 14:26). The mystical tradition calls this transforming union—the person’s will so aligned with God’s that hearing and obeying are no longer experienced as separate actions: “For it is God who works in you, both to will and to work for his good pleasure” (Phil 2:13).

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³⁶ Abraham Kuyper, “Sphere Sovereignty,” in Abraham Kuyper: A Centennial Reader, ed. James D. Bratt (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1998), 488.

³⁷ Dallas Willard, *Hearing God: Developing a Conversational Relationship with God* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2012), 67–95.

³⁸ John of the Cross, *Dark Night of the Soul*, II.1–3. The dark night of the senses strips dependence on consolation; the dark night of the spirit strips spiritual pride itself.

The person at Level 5 is typically less certain about their own spiritual maturity than at any previous level. They are more aware of remaining sin, more dependent on grace, more humble about their hearing. This is the theological parallel to the self-assessment problem: the most mature are the least likely to report themselves as mature.

Where Each Tradition Plateaus

Each tradition has a characteristic level where it tends to plateau. The reformed tradition tends to plateau at Level 2: excellent doctrine and faithful practice in the means of grace, but without the affective internalization that moves knowledge from head to heart. The evangelical tradition tends to plateau at the Level 2–3 transition: active spiritual practices but compartmentalized Christianity that struggles to integrate hearing God into non-spiritual domains. The charismatic tradition tends to plateau at Level 3: genuine encounters with God but sensation-dependence that resists the dark night's stripping of felt experience. The mystical tradition tends to plateau at Level 3–4: deep interior experience that may neglect concrete obedience in the external world. No tradition alone can produce Level 5 maturity. They need each other.

TFT explains these plateaus as field imbalances. The reformed tradition develops extraordinary Truth field strength but weak Goodness-Beauty coupling: the doctrine is precise, but it has not transformed the affections. The evangelical tradition develops the Goodness field (behavioral obedience) but often instrumentalizes Truth and neglects Beauty. The charismatic tradition develops strong Beauty field dynamics (experiential intensity, aesthetic attraction) but can be destabilized by perturbation when the Truth field provides insufficient structural constraint. The mystical tradition achieves deep Beauty-Goodness coupling (contemplation transforming character) but sometimes neglects Truth's structural constraints and Goodness's external expression. Full maturity—Level 5—requires all three fields fully coupled: Truth

informing Goodness, Goodness expressing Beauty, Beauty drawing the person deeper into Truth. This is the TFT Peace state, and it is what no single tradition can produce alone.³⁹

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³⁹ In TFT terms, the eschatological Peace (Shalom) state corresponds to a stable minimum where all field time-derivatives vanish and the Hessian matrix is positive definite—the system has reached its maximum flourishing configuration and resists perturbation.

Small-Group Spiritual Maturity: A Parallel Taxonomy

A group has emergent properties that are not merely the average of individual scores. Five individually mature believers can form a spiritually immature group—one that avoids conflict, stays superficial, and functions as a social club with prayer appended. The New Testament envisions spiritual maturity as inherently communal: “The body does not consist of one member but of many” (1 Cor 12:14). The “one another” commands—over fifty in the New Testament—are group-level maturity indicators by definition.⁴⁰

TFT’s field equations apply at the group level because the Lagrangian structure is scale-invariant: the same Truth-Goodness-Beauty dynamics that govern individual internalization also govern group culture.⁴¹ A group develops its own field configuration—its own characteristic coupling of Truth (what the group knows and believes together), Goodness (what the group practices and values), and Beauty (the aesthetic coherence of the group’s common life). Five individuals with strong individual field coupling can form a group with weak collective coupling: the fields are present in the members but not in the relational space between them. The group’s spiritual maturity is a property of its shared field, not the sum of its individual fields.

Drawing on Levi and Askay’s *Group Dynamics for Teams*,⁴² this section proposes a five-level small-group taxonomy parallel to Krathwohl’s individual taxonomy, incorporating insights

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⁴⁰ The exact count depends on textual variants and how phrases are grouped. Frequently cited as fifty-nine distinct commands. See, e.g., Jerry Bridges, *True Community: The Biblical Practice of Koinonia* (Colorado Springs: NavPress, 2012), 175–80.

⁴¹ TFT’s field equations apply at multiple scales because the Lagrangian structure is scale-invariant. Individual, group, congregational, denominational, and universal-church systems each instantiate the same Truth-Goodness-Beauty field dynamics on progressively larger configuration spaces.

⁴² Daniel Levi and David A. Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 6th ed. (Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE, 2021).

from Tuckman's stage model,⁴³ group norm theory, social loafing research, and groupthink analysis.

Level 1: Assembling (Parallel to Receiving)

The group gathers with nominal agreement on purpose. Leadership is entirely centralized—the leader selects content, facilitates discussion, and initiates prayer. If the leader is absent, the group cancels or defaults to socializing. Members are recipients, not contributors, to the discernment process. Measurement is straightforward: attendance consistency, whether the group opens a Bible or prays. Levi's research emphasizes that norms established in these early meetings persist throughout the group's life.⁴⁴ A group that begins with surface-level sharing establishes a norm of surface-level interaction that becomes nearly impossible to break.

Level 2: Interacting (Parallel to Responding)

Members actively engage with each other rather than only with the leader. Discussion becomes dialogical. Tuckman's storming phase often begins here as genuine opinions surface. How the group handles its first real disagreement is one of the most consequential moments in its life—Levi's research shows that groups suppressing conflict at this stage establish avoidance norms that freeze the group permanently.⁴⁵ Social loafing becomes visible: a few members carry the discussion while others observe.⁴⁶ Measurement should track participation distribution, not just average engagement.

Level 3: Trusting (Parallel to Valuing)

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⁴³ Bruce W. Tuckman and Mary Ann C. Jensen, "Stages of Small Group Development Revisited," *Group and Organizational Studies* 2, no. 4 (1977): 419–27.

⁴⁴ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

⁴⁵ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 131–48. Levi distinguishes task conflict (disagreement about work content), process conflict (disagreement about logistics and procedures), and relationship conflict (personal friction).

⁴⁶ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 105–18.

The group develops genuine relational trust enabling vulnerability—what Levi calls psychological safety.⁴⁷ Members share honest struggles, doubts, and failures without being prompted by curriculum. The critical distinction, drawn from group norm theory, is between performative trust (the stated norm is “we’re vulnerable here” while the behavioral norm is carefully managed self-disclosure) and normative trust (the behavioral norm genuinely supports disclosure and challenge).⁴⁸ The group that performs vulnerability looks identical to the group that has genuinely internalized it—the same indistinguishability problem that plagues individual measurement. Three pathological expressions threaten at this level: emotional enmeshment (confusing intensity with depth), reformed gatekeeping (theological filtering that quenches the Spirit), and Levi’s groupthink (high cohesion producing confirmation bias rather than genuine discernment).⁴⁹

Level 4: Integrating (Parallel to Organization)

The group develops shared mental models—Levi’s term for collective understanding of both task and relational processes.⁵⁰ Leadership is distributed: multiple members can facilitate, initiate care, and shepherd others.⁵¹ Levi’s leadership absence test applies: if the designated leader is absent for two weeks, does the group function at the same level? If yes, the discernment culture is embedded in the group, not housed in one person. The group demonstrates team reflexivity—the ability to evaluate and improve its own processes.⁵² Conflict is primarily process conflict

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⁴⁷ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74. Levi draws on Amy C. Edmondson, “Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams,” *Administrative Science Quarterly* 44, no. 2 (1999): 350–83.

⁴⁸ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

⁴⁹ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 175–90.

⁵⁰ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 149–52.

⁵¹ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 197–215.

⁵² Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 153–55.

(disagreements about how to work) resolved through negotiated norms rather than leader intervention.⁵³ Bonhoeffer's vision of authentic Christian community becomes operational.⁵⁴

Level 5: Reproducing (Parallel to Characterization)

The group's culture has become so deeply internalized that it reproduces in new contexts. Members carry the group's DNA into other relationships and settings. The group sends members out to lead new groups without experiencing this as loss. New members are formed by the group's culture rather than the group being destabilized by newcomers. This is Levi's concept of organizational learning transfer—practices and culture successfully replicated beyond the original team.⁵⁵ The ultimate test: can a member plant a new group in a different context and reproduce the culture of corporate discernment? The paradigmatic biblical example is Acts 13:1–3, where the Antioch church heard God together, obeyed at great cost by releasing their best leaders, and produced the Gentile mission that changed history.

Group Pathologies at Each Level

Levi's group dynamics framework reveals pathological expressions at each level that church leaders must recognize.⁵⁶ At Level 1, attendance becomes identity—showing up equals faithfulness. At Level 2, leader dependence creates a spectator culture. At Level 3, groupthink produces the “holy huddle”—intensely bonded, deeply trusting, and completely useless for mission.⁵⁷ At Level 4, institutional calcification replaces Spirit-dependence with procedural comfort. At Level 5, cloning—reproducing identical groups rather than contextually adapted

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⁵³ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 131–48. Levi distinguishes task conflict (disagreement about work content), process conflict (disagreement about logistics and procedures), and relationship conflict (personal friction).

⁵⁴ Bonhoeffer, *Life Together*, 26–30. Bonhoeffer warns that community built on human ideals rather than divine reality inevitably becomes a source of disillusionment.

⁵⁵ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58.

⁵⁶ Daniel Levi and David A. Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 6th ed. (Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE, 2021).

⁵⁷ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 175–90.

ones—mistakes uniformity for faithfulness. Recognition of these pathologies is itself a measurement tool: a trained observer can diagnose group level partly by identifying which pathology threatens.

The Parable of the Sower Applied to Group Soil

The Parable of the Sower applies to groups as powerfully as to individuals, because a group develops a collective “soil condition”—a shared receptivity to God’s word that is a property of the relational system, not merely of its individual members. A group of individually receptive people can create a collectively hard path; a group with strong relational infrastructure can create good soil even for members whose individual receptivity is shallow. The group’s soil is its culture.

The path group has assembled (Level 1) but its culture prevents the word from penetrating. The meeting format itself functions as hardened ground: content is consumed passively, discussion stays abstract, and the word bounces off the group’s surface without entering its relational life. The leader teaches; members nod; everyone goes home unchanged. Levi’s norm research explains the mechanism: if the group’s earliest meetings establish a norm of surface-level interaction, that norm hardens like a path under foot traffic.⁵⁸ The word is sown every week, but the group’s culture snatches it away before it can germinate. Church leaders often mistake attendance for reception—the group is gathering, therefore it is receiving. The Sower parable says otherwise: gathering is not receiving if the soil is impenetrable.

The rocky-ground group has reached Level 2–3 and is characterized by enthusiasm without depth. These groups often form around a shared experience—a retreat, a crisis, a charismatic leader—and generate intense early connection. Members report feeling deeply

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⁵⁸ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 67–78.

known. The group “immediately receives the word with joy.” But the root system is shallow because the group’s trust is performative rather than normative: the stated norm is vulnerability, but the behavioral norm is carefully managed self-disclosure that avoids genuine cost.⁵⁹ When tribulation comes—a painful conflict, a member’s moral failure, a leader transition, external pressure on the church—the group has no root in itself. It lacks the organizational depth (Level 4) to survive disruption. These are the groups that collapse spectacularly, leaving members more cynical about community than before. The leader absence test is diagnostic: if the group cannot function when its leader is gone for two weeks, its root system is in one person, not in the group’s culture.

The thorny-ground group has genuine trust (Level 3) but has not organized its collective life around the word’s priorities (Level 4). The “cares of the world” at group level are schedule pressure (“we’re all too busy to meet this week”), competing loyalties (members’ primary relational investments are elsewhere), and mission drift (the group becomes a support group, a social club, or a theological debate society rather than a discerning body). The “deceitfulness of riches” at group level is the comfort of the status quo—the group is pleasant enough that no one wants to risk the discomfort of deeper obedience. Levi identifies this as the groupthink pathology: high cohesion producing confirmation bias rather than genuine discernment.⁶⁰ The thorny-ground group bears no fruit because it has never subordinated its competing values—comfort, harmony, self-preservation—to the word’s demand for costly obedience. These groups can persist for years, meeting faithfully, sharing warmly, and producing nothing of kingdom consequence.

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⁵⁹ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74. Levi draws on Amy C. Edmondson, “Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams,” *Administrative Science Quarterly* 44, no. 2 (1999): 350–83.

⁶⁰ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 175–90.

The good-soil group has integrated the word into its collective character (Levels 4–5). Its culture—the norms, relational patterns, and shared practices—has been so thoroughly shaped by the word that fruit production is organic rather than programmatic. The varying yields—thirty, sixty, a hundredfold—apply to groups as well: not every good-soil group produces the same quantity of fruit, but every good-soil group produces fruit with patience. Luke’s qualifier is essential for groups: “hold it fast in an honest and good heart, and bear fruit with patience” (Luke 8:15). The honest heart at group level is normative trust—the group’s actual behavior matches its stated values. The patience is the willingness to sustain the practices of corporate discernment through seasons of drought, confusion, and apparent fruitlessness—the corporate dark night that strips the group of felt confirmation and leaves it dependent on nothing but the word and the Spirit.

The Sower parable thus provides church leaders with a diagnostic question more penetrating than any survey: *What kind of soil is this group?* Is the word bouncing off the surface of polite discussion (path)? Is there enthusiastic reception with no root system to survive pressure (rocky ground)? Is there genuine spiritual life being choked by competing commitments and the comfort of the status quo (thorns)? Or has the word been so deeply integrated into the group’s culture that fruit is the natural, patient, inevitable result (good soil)? A trained observer can answer this question in three meetings. No survey instrument can answer it at all.

Hearing and Obeying God Together: The Small-Group Taxonomy Applied

The fundamental shift from individual to group hearing is this: the Spirit distributes hearing across the body. One member receives a word, another tests it, another sees how to apply it, another has the courage to act on it. No single person carries the full signal. “To each is given the manifestation of the Spirit for the common good” (1 Cor 12:7).

Levels 1–2: From Consuming to Processing Together

At Level 1, hearing God is leader-mediated. The leader teaches; members listen. Prayer requests are informational rather than discernment-oriented. At Level 2, the group begins processing together. Members build on each other’s contributions. Paul’s instruction becomes operative: “When you come together, each one has a hymn, a lesson, a revelation, a tongue, or an interpretation. Let all things be done for building up” (1 Cor 14:26). The critical phrase is “each one has”—the Spirit distributes, and the group must learn to receive from multiple sources. What moves the group forward is the leader asking genuine questions rather than curriculum questions—questions they do not already know the answer to.

Level 3: Developing Collective Discernment

Trust enables the group to move from discussing God’s Word to discerning God’s voice together. Members bring real decisions to the group for genuine input, not just prayer support.⁶¹ Corporate listening prayer becomes regular: the group prays about a specific question and then shares what they received, noting convergences and exploring divergences.⁶² The reformed tradition provides guardrails—testing impressions against the whole counsel of Scripture. The

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⁶¹ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 72–74. Levi draws on Amy C. Edmondson, “Psychological Safety and Learning Behavior in Work Teams,” *Administrative Science Quarterly* 44, no. 2 (1999): 350–83.

⁶² Dallas Willard, *Hearing God: Developing a Conversational Relationship with God* (Downers Grove, IL: InterVarsity, 2012), 67–95.

charismatic tradition contributes prophetic community: “Let two or three prophets speak, and let the others weigh what is said” (1 Cor 14:29). The mystical tradition contributes corporate contemplation—extended shared silence in which the group listens together, along with group examen that builds collective pattern recognition over time.

Level 4: Operating as a Discerning Body

The group has developed an integrated practice of corporate hearing and obeying. Individual members’ hearing is naturally submitted to the group for testing; the group’s collective discernment naturally informs individual decisions.⁶³ The group also hears God about itself—its own health, blind spots, and calling.⁶⁴ Obedience has become corporate: the group acts together, not just individually. The reformed tradition contributes systematic accountability and connection to the broader church’s authority. The evangelical tradition contributes missional orientation: “What is God saying to us for the sake of others?” The charismatic tradition contributes fluency in the Spirit’s gifts as regular discernment inputs—the group knows its own spiritual giftedness map. The mystical tradition contributes apophatic discernment—hearing God not only in what is present but in what is absent.

Level 5: The Group’s Hearing Culture Multiplies

Former members lead new groups exhibiting the same culture—not from following a manual but from having been formed by the original group’s culture.⁶⁵ Members instinctively create conditions for honest dialogue, prayerful discernment, and courageous obedience in every context they enter. The group’s culture has become portable. The reformed tradition produces

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⁶³ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 149–52.

⁶⁴ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 153–55.

⁶⁵ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58.

theological depth in the broader church. The evangelical tradition produces witnesses whose most powerful testimony is not individual conversion but communal discernment. The charismatic tradition produces prophetic maturity—members who carry the Spirit’s gifts with humility and accuracy forged by years of corporate testing. The mystical tradition produces contemplatives-in-action who bring interior stillness into chaotic situations.

What Each Tradition Must Surrender

To reach Level 5, each tradition must release its characteristic idol. The reformed must surrender control—genuinely expecting the Spirit to speak through the community in ways the text alone could not have predicted, without abandoning sola scriptura. The evangelical must surrender productivity—learning that sometimes the most obedient response is to wait. The charismatic must surrender immediacy—accepting that some of God’s most important words come through extended communal process rather than dramatic moments. The mystical must surrender interiority—recognizing that union with God cultivated in contemplation finds completion in the group’s sent obedience in the world: “As you sent me into the world, so I have sent them into the world” (John 17:18).

Congregational Spiritual Maturity: The Church as a System

A church is not merely a collection of individuals or a collection of small groups. It has emergent properties at three distinct levels—individual, group, and congregational—and each level has its own internalization dynamics. The critical insight is that a church’s spiritual maturity is not the average of its members’ scores or even the average of its groups’ scores. It is a property of the system: how the levels interact, what the church’s culture rewards and produces, and what happens to the people who are not in any group at all. NCD attempted to measure at the church level but measured organizational climate through thirty leaders rather than internalization depth across the congregation. REVEAL measured individuals and aggregated upward, losing the systemic properties. The taxonomy must therefore extend to the congregational level with its own five-level framework.

In TFT terms, a congregation’s institutional culture functions as the background manifold on which individual and group field dynamics evolve.⁶⁶ What the church measures, funds, rewards, and communicates shapes the configuration space within which individuals and groups seek stable equilibria. A church whose institutional culture rewards attendance metrics (Truth-surface) without assessing transformation (Goodness-depth) creates a background manifold that makes Level 5 individual formation geometrically harder—the configuration space is constrained in ways that favor shallow attractors over deep ones. Conversely, a church whose culture genuinely values formation creates a manifold that facilitates the coupling of all three fields at every level within its ecosystem.

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⁶⁶ TFT’s field equations apply at multiple scales because the Lagrangian structure is scale-invariant. Individual, group, congregational, denominational, and universal-church systems each instantiate the same Truth-Goodness-Beauty field dynamics on progressively larger configuration spaces.

Level 1: Gathering (Parallel to Receiving)

The church attracts and holds a congregation. People show up for worship, hear preaching, and experience the liturgy or service. The church is doing Level 1 work for the broader population—creating conditions for Receiving. Measurement here is straightforward and churches already do it well: attendance trends, visitor retention, and demographic reach. Level 1 is the church's reach—the total number of people it regularly exposes to the word. The question is what happens to them after exposure.

Level 2: Connecting (Parallel to Responding)

The church has created pathways from the gathering into deeper engagement—small groups, serving teams, classes, mentoring relationships. People move from passive attendance to active participation. The critical metric is the connection rate: what percentage of regular attenders are in some form of relational structure beyond Sunday morning? This is where the people not in a small group become the most diagnostically important population. They are the church's Level 1–2 failure rate. If a church of five hundred has one hundred twenty people in small groups, it has a twenty-four percent connection rate—meaning seventy-six percent of its regular attenders have not moved beyond Receiving to Responding in any relational context.⁶⁷ That seventy-six percent is not a neutral population; it is a measurement of the church's discipleship system effectiveness at the most basic transition.

The reasons people do not connect are themselves diagnostic. Are pathways unclear (structural failure)? Are groups unappealing or inaccessible (cultural failure)? Are people content with anonymous consumption (the path soil at congregational scale)? Do people try groups and leave (rocky ground—the church's relational culture cannot sustain engagement)?

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⁶⁷ Vannoy, "Measuring the Usefulness," 64–67.

Level 3: Cultivating (Parallel to Valuing)

The church's culture has shifted from activity-centered to transformation-centered. This is not about programming but about what the church actually values versus what it says it values—the same stated-norm versus behavioral-norm distinction Levi identifies at the group level, applied congregationally. Observable indicators include: Does the budget reflect discipleship as a genuine priority, or is it dominated by facilities and Sunday production? When staff are hired, is formation capacity weighted equally with programmatic competence? Do elders and deacons model vulnerability and growth, or do they model institutional management? When a program is cut, is the criterion “Is this producing transformation?” or “How many people attend it?” The church at Level 3 has stopped counting attendance as its primary success metric and started asking qualitative questions about depth. This is rare. Most churches talk about transformation while measuring participation—the congregational equivalent of the Pharisee problem.

Level 4: Integrating (Parallel to Organization)

The church has aligned its systems—governance, staffing, budget, programming, leadership development, and mission—around a coherent discipleship vision. At Level 4, the church's small groups are not a program alongside other programs; they are the primary relational infrastructure through which the church's mission operates. Leadership development is not a class but a pipeline: the church systematically identifies, mentors, deploys, and evaluates leaders at every level. The preaching ministry, the worship ministry, the missions program, and the mercy ministries are all integrated around the same formation vision rather than operating as independent silos.

The diagnostic test for Level 4 is the leadership transition test—the congregational parallel to Levi’s leader absence test for groups.⁶⁸ When the senior pastor leaves, does the church’s discipleship culture survive? If the culture is housed in one leader’s vision and charisma, the church is Level 2–3 regardless of how sophisticated its programming appears. If the culture persists through pastoral transition, it has been genuinely internalized into the church’s institutional DNA.

Level 5: Reproducing (Parallel to Characterization)

The church’s culture of spiritual formation has become so deeply embedded that it reproduces—in new campuses, church plants, network churches, and leaders sent into other contexts. Members who leave carry the church’s formation DNA into new settings. The church produces leaders who can plant new churches that exhibit the same depth, not because they follow the mother church’s model but because they have been formed by its culture.⁶⁹ The ultimate test: can the church release its best leaders—its Barnabases and Sauls—without experiencing this as institutional loss? Acts 13:1–3 applies at the congregational level as powerfully as at the group level. A Level 5 church is generative by nature; its instinct is to give away rather than accumulate.

The Mixed-Population Problem

A church of five hundred might contain three hundred eighty people at Level 1 only (attending worship, not connected further), seventy at Level 2 (in a group or serving team), thirty at Level 3 (genuinely valuing transformation), fifteen at Level 4 (integrated life of discipleship, serving as

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⁶⁸ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 197–215.

⁶⁹ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58. Levi notes that most teams’ effectiveness is locked inside the team and disappears when the team dissolves or members leave.

leaders), and five at Level 5 (characterological maturity, capable of reproducing the culture). No single instrument can assess all five populations because they require different measurement methods. But the distribution itself is a primary diagnostic. A healthy church should look like a funnel with intentional movement—not a flat line stuck at Level 1.

For the Level 1 population not in groups, the measurement is primarily structural—are pathways visible, accessible, and culturally compelling? The most important metric is the transition rate: of those who attend for six months or more, what percentage moves into relational engagement? For the Level 2 population in groups, the group taxonomy provides the framework, but the church-level question is whether the groups themselves are distributed across the group taxonomy or clustered at Levels 1–2. For the Level 3–5 formation core, peer assessment, pastoral observation, and scenario-based evaluation become essential. These are the people who should be assessed with the most rigorous methods—not because they need it most but because they are the church’s formation infrastructure. Their health determines everyone else’s trajectory.

The Sower at Congregational Scale

The church as a whole has a soil condition—an aggregate culture that either facilitates or blocks internalization. The path church has excellent preaching, full pews, and no relational infrastructure; the word is sown beautifully every Sunday and bounces off the congregation’s surface. The rocky-ground church has high-energy programming, exciting events, and strong initial connections, but people leave within eighteen months because the relational root system is shallow. The thorny-ground church has genuine community, good small groups, and real spiritual life, but has never organized its collective priorities around the costly demands of the kingdom—budget goes to comfort, staffing goes to maintaining programs, and mission is an add-

on. The good-soil church has so thoroughly integrated the word into its culture—its governance, relationships, priorities, and willingness to sacrifice—that fruit production is natural: leaders emerge without being recruited, groups multiply without being programmed, and members carry the culture into their workplaces, neighborhoods, and families.

Denominational Spiritual Maturity: Institutional Internalization

A denomination is not merely a collection of churches any more than a church is merely a collection of individuals. It has emergent properties—theological culture, institutional memory, governance reflexes, credentialing systems, resource allocation patterns—that shape what happens in every church, group, and individual within its ecosystem. The critical insight at this scale is that a denomination’s actual theology of spiritual maturity is revealed not by its doctrinal statements but by what it measures, funds, rewards, and reproduces. Every denomination says it values spiritual formation. What it actually values is diagnosed by where it directs institutional energy.

At the denominational scale, TFT’s nested field structure reaches its most consequential expression. The denomination’s institutional culture constitutes the outermost background manifold—the curvature of the space within which all congregational, group, and individual field dynamics unfold.⁷⁰ A denomination that measures only Truth-surface outputs (doctrinal fidelity, baptism counts, membership rolls) while ignoring Goodness-depth (character transformation) and Beauty-coupling (the aesthetic coherence of formation culture) warps the entire manifold. Every church within the denomination must fight against the curvature of the institutional space to pursue deep formation. A denomination aligned at Level 4–5 straightens the manifold—it creates institutional conditions where the natural field dynamics carry individuals, groups, and churches toward Glory rather than away from it.⁷¹

Level 1: Affiliating (Parallel to Receiving)

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⁷⁰ TFT’s field equations apply at multiple scales because the Lagrangian structure is scale-invariant. Individual, group, congregational, denominational, and universal-church systems each instantiate the same Truth-Goodness-Beauty field dynamics on progressively larger configuration spaces.

⁷¹ Glory in TFT corresponds to the attractor state—the global maximum of combined field strength where Truth, Goodness, and Beauty achieve their fullest mutual expression. Glory is Beauty-at-eschatological-completion.

The denomination exists as an identifiable entity—churches affiliate, share a name, subscribe to common doctrinal standards, and participate in a shared governance structure. The denomination’s relationship to spiritual maturity at this level is rhetorical. Formation language appears in founding documents, mission statements, and convention speeches. But the denomination’s operational infrastructure—what it actually builds, funds, and staffs—is organized around other priorities: church planting metrics, membership totals, giving receipts, institutional maintenance, or theological boundary enforcement. The diagnostic question: if one removed all references to spiritual formation from the denomination’s budget, staffing chart, and annual report, what would actually change? If the answer is “almost nothing,” the denomination is at Level 1 regardless of its stated theology.

Level 2: Programming (Parallel to Responding)

The denomination creates formation resources and programs—published curricula, assessment tools, training events for pastors, and discipleship initiatives. Churches are encouraged to adopt these resources. The denomination measures uptake: how many churches purchased the curriculum, how many pastors attended the training, how many congregations administered the assessment. Level 2 denominational work is genuinely useful—churches need resources. But the characteristic failure is measuring resource distribution rather than formation outcomes.⁷² The denomination knows how many copies of the discipleship curriculum it sold; it does not know whether anyone was transformed by it. Vannoy’s research on the DPA illustrates the problem: the tool was distributed to churches, but even enthusiastic adopters achieved only eleven percent

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⁷² Hawkins and Parkinson, *Move*, 18–25. REVEAL’s core finding—that church activity does not predict spiritual growth—is itself evidence that the institutional apparatus optimized for producing activity does not reliably produce transformation.

participation, and the “next steps” designed to produce change scored lowest in usefulness.⁷³ The denomination distributed the tool; it cannot verify whether the tool produced the outcome it was designed to measure.

Level 3: Prioritizing (Parallel to Valuing)

The denomination begins to genuinely value formation outcomes over institutional metrics. This manifests in concrete, observable shifts: credentialing processes for pastors begin to include formation assessment alongside doctrinal examination and academic credentials. Budget allocation shifts from program production to formation infrastructure—training spiritual directors, developing pastoral mentorship networks, funding longitudinal studies rather than one-time assessments. The denomination’s reporting structure changes: instead of asking churches only for attendance, baptism, and giving numbers, it begins asking qualitative questions about transformation, group health, and leadership development.

The critical transition at Level 3 is the same as at every other scale: the shift from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation. A Level 2 denomination promotes formation because it is strategically smart—churches that disciple well tend to grow and give. A Level 3 denomination pursues formation because it has internalized the conviction that making disciples is the mission, regardless of whether it produces institutional growth. This distinction is tested when formation priorities conflict with institutional ones—when a church that is deeply forming people but not growing numerically is treated with the same respect as a numerically thriving church that may be producing Level 2 consumers rather than Level 5 disciples.

Level 4: Aligning (Parallel to Organization)

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⁷³ Vannoy, “Measuring the Usefulness,” 64–67.

The denomination has aligned its systems—governance, credentialing, funding, evaluation, communication, and theological education—around a coherent formation vision. This is institutional integration, and it is extraordinarily rare. At Level 4, seminary and Bible college curricula within the denomination’s ecosystem include not only theological education but formation assessment—students are evaluated not just on what they know but on who they are becoming. The denomination does not credential pastors who score well on doctrinal exams but show no evidence of personal formation or capacity to form others.

Church health evaluations move beyond the metrics that denominations typically track. Rather than assessing churches primarily on attendance, baptisms, and financial giving, the denomination assesses the distribution of its churches across the congregational taxonomy—how many are at Level 1, how many at Level 3, how many at Level 5. The denomination’s strategic resources flow toward moving the distribution upward rather than merely counting total membership. Pastoral care for pastors is organized around formation rather than crisis management—the denomination builds ongoing formation structures into the expected lifecycle of pastoral ministry.

The diagnostic test for Level 4 is the governance alignment test: when the denomination faces a resource allocation decision, does the formation vision actually govern the decision, or does it lose to institutional pragmatism? A Level 4 denomination will sometimes make institutionally costly decisions because the formation vision demands it—closing a program that draws crowds but does not form people, redirecting funds from facilities to mentoring, refusing to credential a gifted leader who has not demonstrated formation depth.

Level 5: Reproducing (Parallel to Characterization)

The denomination's formation culture has become so deeply embedded in its institutional DNA that it reproduces across generations of leadership, survives institutional crises, and exports into other denominational and cross-denominational contexts. The formation vision is not housed in a single leader, a single era, or a single initiative; it is the character of the institution—pervasive, consistent, and predictable.⁷⁴ At Level 5, the denomination produces churches that produce groups that produce individuals who carry the formation DNA wherever they go—including into other denominations.

The historical test for Level 5 is severe: has the denomination maintained its formation depth through at least one full generational transition of leadership? Many denominations experience a formation season under a gifted leader or during a renewal movement, only to lose it when the founder dies, the movement institutionalizes, or the next generation inherits the structure without the spirit. A Level 5 denomination has solved the transmission problem—the formation culture survives the people who created it.

Where Denominational Traditions Plateau

Each denominational tradition has a characteristic plateau, shaped by its theological commitments and institutional incentives. Reformed denominations tend to plateau at Level 2–3: they produce excellent theological resources and prioritize doctrinal fidelity in credentialing, but the institutional infrastructure is organized around theological correctness rather than affective transformation. A pastor can be ordained with a sterling theological exam and no evidence that the doctrines he affirms have moved from his head to his character.

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⁷⁴ Levi and Askay, *Group Dynamics for Teams*, 255–58. Levi notes that most teams' effectiveness is locked inside the team and disappears when the team dissolves or members leave.

Evangelical denominations tend to plateau at Level 2. They are extraordinarily productive at the programming level—curricula, conferences, assessment tools, training events—but the institutional incentive structure rewards activity metrics rather than formation depth.⁷⁵ The REVEAL study’s finding that church activity does not predict spiritual growth is a denominational-level indictment: the entire evangelical institutional apparatus is optimized for producing activity, and the activity does not reliably produce transformation.

Charismatic networks tend to plateau at Level 3. They genuinely value the Spirit’s work and the experiential dimension of formation, but the institutional structure often centers on a founding apostolic leader whose personal gifting substitutes for systemic formation infrastructure. The network is at Level 3 as long as the founder is alive; when the founder transitions, the network discovers that its formation culture was housed in a person rather than embedded in institutional DNA. The leadership transition test is particularly diagnostic for charismatic networks.

Mainline denominations tend to plateau at Level 1—not because they lack theological sophistication about formation but because institutional survival concerns have displaced formation as the operative priority. When a denomination is losing membership and closing churches, institutional energy flows toward maintenance and marketing rather than formation. The painful irony is that deeper formation is likely the only path to genuine renewal, but the institution cannot prioritize it while in survival mode. This is the thorny ground at denominational scale: the cares of institutional survival choke the formation mission.

The Sower at Denominational Scale

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⁷⁵ Hawkins and Parkinson, *Move*, 18–25. REVEAL’s core finding—that church activity does not predict spiritual growth—is itself evidence that the institutional apparatus optimized for producing activity does not reliably produce transformation.

The path denomination produces doctrinal statements about formation, hosts conventions where formation is discussed, and publishes resources. The word bounces off the institutional surface. No structural change follows the rhetoric. The rocky-ground denomination launches a major formation initiative—a new assessment tool, a church health movement, a discipleship emphasis year. There is initial enthusiasm and widespread adoption. But the initiative has no institutional root system; when leadership changes or the next strategic priority emerges, it withers. The thorny-ground denomination has genuine formation infrastructure but its institutional incentive structure chokes it: the metrics that determine funding, recognition, and advancement are still numerical, and pastors who build deep, small churches receive less institutional support than pastors who build wide, shallow ones. The good-soil denomination has aligned its entire institutional apparatus around the conviction that making disciples is the mission—credentialing, funding, evaluation, and governance all serve the formation vision, and the denomination bears fruit with patience across generations.

Measuring at the Denominational Level

A denomination wanting honest assessment would need a multi-layered approach. Institutional analysis examines where the money actually goes, what the credentialing process evaluates, what metrics determine which churches receive resources, and what happens to formation initiatives when leadership transitions—all publicly observable, requiring no survey. Church distribution mapping assesses a representative sample of churches using the congregational taxonomy to determine what percentage are at each level. A denomination where eighty percent of churches are at Level 1–2 has a systemic soil problem that no amount of programming will fix. A leadership formation audit evaluates the formation depth of the denomination’s top leaders—if the leadership core is operating at Level 2 with Level 5 vocabulary, the entire system is

compromised. Finally, longitudinal outcome tracking follows formation outcomes over five-to-ten-year windows rather than relying on one-time assessment snapshots, and cross-generational persistence analysis asks whether the denomination's formation effectiveness has survived at least one full leadership generation.

The Universal Church: Measuring Spiritual Maturity at the Catholic Scale

The Nicene Creed confesses the church as “one, holy, catholic, and apostolic.” These four marks are not merely aspirational adjectives; they are claims about the church’s ontological identity—what the church *is* by virtue of Christ’s constitution of it. Yet the church’s empirical reality is conspicuously fractured: over 45,000 denominations worldwide, mutual excommunications spanning centuries, and theological traditions so estranged from one another that they cannot share the Eucharist—the sacrament that signifies unity. The taxonomy developed in this paper applies at this scale as well, and the diagnosis is sobering.

Krathwohl’s affective domain taxonomy does not merely describe increasing *individual* commitment; it describes the progressive internalization of any value system across any organizational level. At each prior scale—small group, congregation, denomination—the taxonomy has revealed how an entity can confess a commitment it has not internalized: the denomination that speaks of formation while measuring only attendance, the congregation that confesses community while structuring anonymity. The universal church’s confession of unity, holiness, catholicity, and apostolicity is susceptible to the same diagnostic: the church may be at Level 1 (receiving these marks rhetorically) while operating at far lower levels of actual internalization.

The critical distinction at this scale is between the church’s *esse* (being) and its *bene esse* (well-being)—a distinction the Reformers invoked regarding church governance but which applies equally to formation. Christ constituted the church as one body (Eph 4:4–6). That ontological unity is not destroyed by empirical division, but the church’s failure to *manifest* its given unity is a formation failure at the highest organizational scale—a Level 1 confession

without Level 4–5 operationalization. The taxonomy helps diagnose exactly where the failure lies.

In TFT terms, the universal church occupies the largest configuration space—the outermost manifold whose curvature sets the boundary conditions for all denominational, congregational, group, and individual field dynamics within it.⁷⁶ When this manifold is fractured—when the universal church has decoupled Truth, Goodness, and Beauty into competing traditions that each claim one transcendental while neglecting the others—the curvature distorts formation at every interior scale. No denomination, church, group, or individual can achieve full-spectrum formation within a fractured catholicity, because each tradition’s characteristic plateau is itself a symptom of the universal church’s fragmentation.

The Nicene Marks as Formation Criteria

Each of the four Nicene marks corresponds to a formation dimension that the taxonomy can diagnose.

One. Unity is the formation goal of the universal church as a body—the eschatological vision of Ephesians 4:13, “until we all attain to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God.” At Level 1, unity is confessed in the Creed but not pursued beyond rhetorical acknowledgment. At Level 2, ecumenical dialogues and joint statements are produced; bilateral commissions issue convergence documents that are received politely and shelved. At Level 3, genuine valuing of other traditions begins—not mere tolerance but the recognition that one’s own tradition is genuinely impoverished without what others carry. At Level 4, institutional structures are reorganized around unity: mutual recognition of baptism, shared mission,

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⁷⁶ TFT’s field equations apply at multiple scales because the Lagrangian structure is scale-invariant. Individual, group, congregational, denominational, and universal-church systems each instantiate the same Truth-Goodness-Beauty field dynamics on progressively larger configuration spaces.

cooperative theological education, and the willingness to receive correction from outside one's own tradition. At Level 5, unity has become characterological—the church's instinct is toward communion rather than competition, and division is experienced as a wound to be healed rather than a boundary to be maintained.

Holy. Holiness at the universal-church scale means that the body of Christ across all traditions is collectively set apart for God's purposes and progressively purified. At Level 1, holiness is affirmed doctrinally. At Level 2, moral standards are promulgated within traditions. At Level 3, traditions begin to examine how their own institutional sins—colonial complicity, abuse cover-ups, cultural captivity—have compromised the church's holiness witness before the world. At Level 4, accountability structures cross denominational lines: traditions hold one another accountable, and the church's holiness is understood as a collective reality damaged by any tradition's failure. At Level 5, the church's holiness has become its visible character before the world—what Jesus prayed for in John 17:21–23: “that they may all be one ... so that the world may believe.” The world's ability to recognize the church's holiness is the ultimate external validation at this scale.

Catholic. Catholicity—universality—means the church's faith is complete, embracing every truth that God has revealed, available to every people and culture, and expressed through the fullness of the Spirit's gifts. In TFT terms, catholicity corresponds to the completeness of the field configuration: all three transcendental fields operating at full strength with proper coupling. At Level 1, catholicity is claimed but functionally denied; each tradition acts as if its slice of the church *is* the church. At Level 2, traditions acknowledge that others exist and may have something to contribute—resource sharing, joint Bible translation projects, humanitarian cooperation. At Level 3, genuine recognition emerges that one's own tradition is incomplete: the

reformed tradition needs the charismatic experience of the Spirit, the charismatic tradition needs reformed doctrinal depth, the evangelical tradition needs the liturgical tradition's aesthetic formation, and all Western traditions need the Eastern church's theology of theosis and communal mysticism. At Level 4, institutions actively pursue complementarity rather than competition. At Level 5, catholicity is the church's operative identity—it instinctively receives from every tradition and culture as complementary expressions of the one Gospel.

Apostolic. Apostolicity means the church remains faithful to the apostles' teaching (Acts 2:42) and continues their mission. At Level 1, each tradition claims apostolic succession or fidelity for itself. At Level 2, common confessional documents—the Apostles' Creed, the Nicene Creed, the Chalcedonian Definition—are acknowledged across traditions as shared apostolic inheritance. At Level 3, traditions begin to recognize that their distinctive emphases represent different faithful developments of the apostolic deposit rather than competitors for it. At Level 4, shared doctrinal formation emerges—theological education that draws on the whole tradition rather than only one stream. At Level 5, the apostolic faith is transmitted intergenerationally across traditions with the confidence that the same Spirit who inspired the apostles continues to illumine the church catholic.

The Five Levels at Universal-Church Scale

Level 1: Receiving—Credal Confession Without Operational Unity

The universal church exists as a recognizable concept—Christians worldwide acknowledge that they belong to something larger than their local church or denomination. The Nicene marks are confessed in liturgy across traditions. But the confession is functionally inert. Denominations operate as self-contained ecosystems with minimal reference to the wider body. The “Christian

church” is an abstraction rather than an operative reality. Measurement at this level is simply participation tracking: what percentage of Christians worldwide even know the Nicene Creed, let alone confess it as binding? Do churches teach their members that they belong to a body larger than their denomination?

Level 2: Responding—Ecumenical Programs and Cooperative Activity

The universal church produces cooperative activity: the World Council of Churches, the Lausanne Movement, bilateral theological dialogues, shared disaster relief through organizations like World Vision, joint Bible translation through the United Bible Societies, and the global prayer movement. These represent genuine institutional responses to the call to unity. Level 2 is characterized by the production of convergence documents—Baptism, Eucharist and Ministry (1982), the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification (1999), and numerous bilateral agreements. The characteristic Level 2 failure is the same as at every other scale: measuring activity rather than outcome. The ecumenical movement knows how many dialogues have been conducted, how many documents produced, how many organizations launched. It is far less certain that any of this has actually produced deeper unity, holiness, catholicity, or apostolicity in the churches on the ground. Convergence documents are received by denominational leaders, discussed in academic journals, and have almost no impact on the average believer’s experience of the church’s unity.

Level 3: Valuing—Genuine Recognition of Mutual Need

Level 3 at the universal-church scale is the rarest and most consequential transition: the point at which a tradition stops treating ecumenical engagement as diplomacy and starts treating it as formation. The diagnostic question is whether the tradition genuinely believes it is incomplete

without what other traditions carry. A reformed denomination that acknowledges in its official theology that it needs charismatic experience of the Spirit—not as a concession but as a conviction—has crossed into Level 3. An Orthodox communion that genuinely receives Western evangelical urgency about personal conversion has crossed into Level 3. The transition is marked by the same shift from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation visible at every other scale: the tradition pursues catholicity not because it is strategically advantageous or culturally expected but because it has internalized the conviction that the body of Christ requires all its members to function.

The theological traditions surveyed in this paper’s analysis of hearing and obeying God provide a concrete illustration. Each tradition’s characteristic plateau—reformed at Level 2, evangelical at the Level 2–3 transition, charismatic at Level 3, mystical at Level 3–4—exists precisely because each tradition has maximized one dimension of the transcendental field while under-developing others. The reformed tradition’s extraordinary Truth-field strength produces doctrinal precision but can leave the Beauty and experiential Goodness fields underdeveloped. The charismatic tradition’s experiential intensity produces strong Beauty-field coupling but can leave Truth-field rigor weak. Only the universal church operating at Level 3 or above can supply what each tradition lacks, because the resources needed for full-spectrum formation are distributed across the whole body.

Level 4: Organization—Structural Catholicity

Level 4 at the universal-church scale would require institutional reorganization around catholicity—structures that make the mutual exchange of formational resources normative rather than exceptional. Concretely: theological seminaries that require students to study in traditions other than their own. Pastoral formation programs that include extended immersion in unfamiliar liturgical, doctrinal, and spiritual traditions. Denominational credentialing processes that evaluate

a candidate's capacity to receive from the whole church, not merely to reproduce the home tradition. Mission partnerships structured around complementary strengths rather than competitive planting.

The historical examples of Level 4 are rare but real. The early ecumenical councils (Nicaea through Chalcedon) represent the church operating at Level 4: diverse traditions—Antiochene, Alexandrian, Roman, Cappadocian—wrestling toward shared formulations that none could have produced alone. The resulting creeds are not compromises but genuine syntheses that required each tradition to receive from the others. The Chalcedonian Definition's "without confusion, without change, without division, without separation" is itself a model of field-coupling: maintaining the integrity of distinct theological emphases while insisting on their unity. The post-Reformation era represents a massive regression from Level 4 to Level 1–2, a regression from which the church has not recovered.

The diagnostic test for Level 4 is the institutional cost test—the same test applied at the denominational level: when pursuing catholicity requires institutional sacrifice, does the tradition actually pay the cost? Does a denomination modify its credentialing process to include cross-traditional formation even though it is more expensive and slower? Does a tradition allow its distinctive emphases to be questioned and refined by outsiders? Does the institution redirect resources from internal growth to cross-traditional partnership? Level 4 catholicity costs something, and the willingness to pay is diagnostic.

Level 5: Characterization—The Church's Eschatological Identity

Level 5 at the universal-church scale is the eschatological horizon toward which the church moves but which it has never fully realized in history. At Level 5, the four Nicene marks would be the church's visible, instinctive, and self-reproducing character before the world. Unity would

not require institutional enforcement because it would be the natural expression of shared identity. Holiness would be the church's collective reputation, not merely individual piety. Catholicity would mean that every local church, whatever its tradition, naturally draws on the fullness of the church's formational inheritance. Apostolicity would mean that the apostolic faith is transmitted with such integrity that it survives not merely generational transitions within traditions but civilizational transitions across cultures.

The New Testament envisions precisely this: "There is one body and one Spirit—just as you were called to the one hope that belongs to your call—one Lord, one faith, one baptism, one God and Father of all, who is over all and through all and in all" (Eph 4:4–6). The sevenfold repetition of "one" is not aspirational but declarative—the church's ontological unity. The task of formation at the universal-church scale is the progressive manifestation of what Christ has already constituted. In TFT terms, the eschatological Glory state corresponds to the moment when all three transcendental fields achieve their maximum values simultaneously across the entire universal manifold—every tradition's distinctive strengths fully expressed and fully coupled, producing the symphonic Beauty that no single tradition could produce alone.

The Sower at Universal-Church Scale

The path soil at the universal-church scale is the tradition that hears the call to catholicity in ecumenical gatherings and Nicene confessions but in which the word never penetrates the institutional surface. The tradition returns to business as usual, its functional self-sufficiency untroubled. The birds that snatch the seed are the tribal loyalties and identity politics that make cross-traditional engagement feel like betrayal rather than obedience.

The rocky-ground tradition responds to the call with initial enthusiasm, sending delegates to ecumenical councils, issuing joint statements, and launching unity initiatives. But there is no

institutional root system. When the ecumenical commitment conflicts with the tradition's internal priorities, when the joint statement requires modifying a cherished practice, when the partnership requires sharing resources rather than competing for converts, when the unity commitment demands that the tradition admit its incompleteness—the enthusiasm withers. Many traditions have experienced this pattern repeatedly: a season of ecumenical openness followed by retrenchment when the cost became apparent.

The thorny-ground tradition has genuine ecumenical conviction—its leaders believe in catholicity, its theologians teach it, its official statements affirm it. But the institutional incentive structure chokes it. Denominational metrics reward internal growth, not cross-traditional partnership. Pastors who invest in ecumenical formation receive less institutional recognition than those who build the brand. Seminary curricula remain overwhelmingly mono-traditional despite official commitment to catholicity. The cares of institutional maintenance and the deceitfulness of tribal identity choke the ecumenical word. This is where most traditions with genuine ecumenical commitment currently reside: the conviction is real, but the institution cannot operationalize it.

The good-soil tradition has aligned its institutional life around the conviction that the church's catholicity is not optional but essential to its formation mission. It structures theological education, pastoral credentialing, mission partnerships, and resource allocation to ensure that its people are formed by the whole church, not merely by one tradition's slice. It bears the fruit of Level 4–5 catholicity with patience—knowing that the full harvest is eschatological, but sowing and cultivating in the present nonetheless.

Measuring at the Universal-Church Scale

Measurement at this scale is necessarily different from measurement at more localized scales. No institution administers the universal church the way a denomination administers its churches. Yet measurement is possible through several approaches.

Cross-traditional formation assessment examines whether believers formed in one tradition can articulate what other traditions contribute to the church's fullness—not merely intellectually but as a formational conviction. A reformed believer who has genuinely internalized the value of charismatic worship, or a Pentecostal who has genuinely internalized the discipline of systematic theology, represents Level 3+ catholicity in a measurable individual. Aggregating such assessments across a tradition provides a rough index of its catholic formation depth.

Institutional complementarity analysis examines whether denominational institutions (seminaries, mission agencies, publishing houses) operate in isolation from other traditions or actively structure cross-traditional engagement. This is publicly observable and requires no survey. Convergence document reception tracking asks not merely whether convergence documents were produced but whether they changed anything: did the Joint Declaration on Justification actually modify how Lutherans and Catholics teach justification to their people? If the answer is no, the universal church is operating at Level 2 regardless of how many documents it produces.

The most sobering metric is the one Jesus himself supplied: “By this all people will know that you are my disciples, if you have love for one another” (John 13:35). The world's perception of the church's unity—or lack thereof—is the ultimate external validation of the universal church's formation at this scale. When 45,000 denominations compete for converts in the same city, the church's witness to its own message of reconciliation is structurally compromised. The

measurement is painfully simple: does the world see one church or many rival organizations?

That external perception measures the universal church's formation at the catholic level more honestly than any internal assessment ever could.

Implications and Conclusion

This paper has argued that the failure to achieve consensus on measuring spiritual maturity stems from a taxonomic failure: existing instruments conflate different levels of affective internalization. Krathwohl's taxonomy provides the diagnostic framework to explain why instruments cluster at Levels 1–3, why Levels 4–5 resist conventional measurement, and what adequate measurement would require at each level. The framework extends across five scales—individual, small group, congregation, denomination, and universal church—revealing the same internalization dynamics at each level of organizational complexity.

Several practical implications follow. First, churches should stop treating any single instrument as a comprehensive maturity measure. Each instrument has a valid operating range within the affective domain taxonomy, and none covers the full spectrum. Second, churches should match the instrument to the affective level they actually need to assess: for Levels 1–2, existing tools (attendance tracking, DPA, REVEAL) are adequate; for Level 3, instruments need redesign around motivation rather than frequency with impression management controls; for Levels 4–5, measurement must move beyond surveys to longitudinal pastoral systems, peer assessment, and scenario-based evaluation.

Third, the small-group taxonomy offers a practical diagnostic framework that requires no survey at all. A church leader can assess group maturity through three observable indicators drawn from group dynamics research: the leadership absence test (does the group function when the leader is absent?), the conflict handling diagnostic (how does the group process disagreement?), and the participation distribution metric (how broadly is engagement shared?). These behavioral observations are more reliable than self-report data at higher levels of internalization.

The Parable of the Sower provides an additional diagnostic lens—perhaps the most pastorally accessible of all. Jesus’ four soils map directly onto the internalization levels: the path (failed Receiving), the rocky ground (Responding without Valuing), the thorny ground (Valuing without Organization), and the good soil (Organization through Characterization). This parabolic framework applies at every scale: individual hearts develop soil conditions, groups develop collective soil cultures, congregations develop institutional soil through their structures and incentives, and denominations develop systemic soil through what they measure, fund, reward, and reproduce. A pastor who can identify the soil condition at each scale has diagnosed not only the current level but the specific barrier preventing further growth.

Fourth, the extension to congregational, denominational, and universal-church scales reveals that the measurement problem is not merely methodological but systemic. A denomination operating at Level 2—programmatically active, metrically obsessed, formationally shallow—constrains every church within it. At the universal-church scale, the fragmentation of the body of Christ into competing traditions that each emphasize different transcendental fields—reformed traditions emphasizing Truth, charismatic traditions emphasizing Beauty, social-gospel traditions emphasizing Goodness—reveals a formation deficit that no single tradition can solve. The denomination’s own measurement systems reinforce the very problem the taxonomy diagnoses. Conversely, a denomination aligned at Level 4–5 creates an ecosystem where formation is normal rather than exceptional, and ecumenical engagement that honestly receives from other traditions moves the universal church toward the catholicity it confesses in the Creed.

Fifth, the application to hearing and obeying God demonstrates that no single theological tradition can produce full-spectrum maturity. Reformed theology provides the content of what

God says; evangelical theology provides the urgency of response; charismatic theology provides the immediacy of the Spirit's ongoing communication; mystical theology provides the depth of interior transformation that makes the other three characterological rather than performative. Each tradition has a characteristic plateau—reformed at Level 2, evangelical at the Level 2–3 transition, charismatic at Level 3, mystical at Level 3–4—and these plateaus replicate fractally from the individual through the denomination. Churches and denominations that draw on only one tradition will systematically plateau at that tradition's characteristic level.

Transcendental Field Theory provides a unifying theoretical framework for these observations. The three transcendental fields—Truth, Goodness, and Beauty—correspond to the dimensions that every tradition emphasizes differently and every instrument measures partially. Krathwohl's internalization levels describe increasing coupling strength between these fields: from zero coupling (path soil, Level 1) through externally sustained coupling (Level 2) to self-sustaining coupling (Level 3) to full integration (Level 4) to characterological equilibrium (Level 5).⁷⁷ The Sower parable maps the failure points where coupling breaks down. The tradition plateaus mark where single-field emphasis reaches its ceiling. The organizational scales—group, congregation, denomination—represent nested manifolds whose curvature either facilitates or constrains the field dynamics at every interior level. The Fall introduced disorder into the configuration space; sanctification is the Spirit's progressive restoration of proper field coupling toward the eschatological Glory state where Truth, Goodness, and Beauty achieve their maximum mutual expression.⁷⁸ This framework does not replace Krathwohl's taxonomy but

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⁷⁷ The Transcendental Field Theory framework treats Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as interacting quantum fields with coupling parameters α , β , and γ , operating on a curved internal manifold. For the full formulation, see the appendix. The framework is heuristic rather than empirically quantified, functioning as a structural analogy for theological reflection.

⁷⁸ TFT models the Fall as the injection of disorder into the field configuration, disrupting the coupling between Truth, Goodness, and Beauty. The background manifold is corrupted, stable minima are displaced, and the system's natural trajectory tends toward fragmentation rather than Glory.

explains why it works: internalization is the progressive coupling of transcendental fields that were designed to operate together but have been fragmented by sin.

The honest conclusion of this analysis is that spiritual maturity at its deepest levels may be partially opaque to measurement by design. The heart's hiddenness is not a bug in the system but a feature of human finitude before a transcendent God. "The LORD sees not as man sees" (1 Sam 16:7). This does not make measurement worthless—it makes it humble. The taxonomy presented here does not solve the measurement problem; it diagnoses why the problem exists, identifies what adequate measurement would require at each level and each scale, and names the specific barriers that prevent existing instruments from capturing the full depth of spiritual transformation. We can measure what we can measure, name what we cannot, and trust that the One who searches hearts knows what our instruments never will.

Appendix: Transcendental Field Theory (TFT)—Complete Framework

Transcendental Field Theory (TFT) extends the conceptual architecture of quantum field theory (QFT)—which can be interpreted as encoding Truth in the sense of objective, law-governed structure of reality—to analogous formalisms that encode Goodness and Beauty. This is not standard physics; it is a structured mathematical analogy that places Truth (QFT), Goodness (GFT—Goodness Field Theory), and Beauty (AFT—Aesthetic Field Theory) in a single variational framework. The framework treats Truth, Goodness, and Beauty as interacting quantum fields with coupling parameters α , β , and γ , and operates as a heuristic model for theological reflection and spiritual formation—not as a replacement for Scripture, creed, or the living tradition of the church.

Part I: Core Mathematical Framework

1. Foundational Identifications

Truth is encoded as consistency with QFT structure—coherent, law-constrained correspondence between theoretical and empirical structure. Goodness is encoded as moral optimality through normative field theory—teleological ordering toward flourishing. Beauty is encoded as structural harmony through aesthetic field theory—harmonic proportion and aesthetic coherence. Together, these form a single variational principle over coupled fields.

2. Fields and Sectors

The Truth Sector (QFT-like) consists of gauge fields with field strength and gauge group, matter fields transforming under the gauge group, and an energy-momentum (stress) tensor. QFT encodes truth through a state space (Hilbert space representing all possible states), self-adjoint

operators encoding measurable truths, a Lagrangian density determining interactions, group actions constraining allowable laws, and expectation values encoding probabilistic truth.

The Goodness Sector (GFT—Normative Field Theory) consists of a normative field χ encoding moral/teleological value, with independent kinetic and potential terms and its own nonlinear dynamics. The Beauty Sector (AFT—Aesthetic Field Theory) consists of an aesthetic field η encoding structural harmony, with patterns allowed, stiffness modified by χ , and its own kinetic and potential structure.

3. Coupling Parameters

The interaction Lagrangian is a sum of three pairwise couplings plus an optional triple coupling. The α -coupling (Truth–Goodness) models information transfer with normative weighting—epistemic justice: truthful information aligned to moral current increases moral value. The β -coupling (Truth–Beauty) encourages structural harmony between physical form and aesthetic pattern. The γ -coupling (Goodness–Beauty) is a potential coupling so that high normative intensity is rewarded when aesthetic harmonics are strong. The δ -coupling (Triple) enforces epistemic-moral-aesthetic coherence.

4. The Unified Lagrangian

The total Lagrangian combines all sectors:

$$\mathcal{L}_{\text{total}} = \mathcal{L}_{\text{Truth}}(\varphi, \partial\varphi) + \mathcal{L}_{\text{Goodness}}(\chi, \partial\chi) + \mathcal{L}_{\text{Beauty}}(\eta, \partial\eta) + \mathcal{L}_{\text{int}}(\varphi, \chi, \eta)$$

The total action $S = \int d^4x \mathcal{L}_{\text{total}}$ yields coupled Euler-Lagrange equations for each field. The fields (φ, χ, η) live on a curved internal manifold—a “field space” (also “configuration space”). The metric $ds^2 = d\varphi^2 + 2\alpha d\varphi d\chi + d\chi^2 + h(\chi)d\eta^2$, where $h(\chi) = 1 - 2\gamma\chi^2$ encodes the Goodness-modulated aesthetic metric, governs field propagation, fields’ natural motion through

configuration space, and the interactions' effective strength. The curvature determines the geometry of spiritual formation.

Part II: Extended Scriptural Anchors

5. Field-Theoretic Classification of Theological Concepts

Being corresponds to the ground field / vacuum state—the background manifold M on which the field-space (ϕ, χ, η) is constructed. Being is not a field alongside Truth, Goodness, and Beauty but the ground upon which all fields are defined.

Life is a derived field (kinetic composite). Life emerges from the interaction of Truth (structure) and Goodness (teleology). Life corresponds to the kinetic energy of the system—dynamic motion through configuration space. Life is Being-in-motion-toward-Good. $L = T(\phi, \chi)$. This explains why Jesus identifies himself as both Truth and Life (John 14:6).

Light functions as the gauge field that enables comparison and transport across the transcendental manifold. Just as electromagnetic gauge fields mediate interactions in QFT, Light mediates the revelation of Truth, the recognition of Goodness, and the perception of Beauty. Light is the visibility condition.

Love is the fundamental coupling that binds all fields together. The α , β , and γ parameters are expressions of Love in different domains. “God is Love” (1 John 4:8) means the divine nature itself is constituted by the relational binding of the transcendentals. Love is the force that curves field-space toward communion.

Glory is the asymptotic attractor / eschatological limit. Glory is the fixed point of maximum beauty, perfect truth, and complete goodness. “From glory to glory” (2 Cor 3:18) is

the renormalization group flow toward this ultimate fixed point. Glory is Beauty-at-eschatological-completion.

Holiness defines the sacred boundary separating permissible from impermissible configurations. $H(\phi, \chi, \eta) \geq 0$ restricts dynamics to the holy submanifold. This explains why holiness is experienced as both attraction (toward the sacred) and prohibition (away from the profane).

Wisdom is a derived field (Truth–Goodness synthesis). $W = \alpha \phi \chi$. Wisdom is knowing-what-to-do—Truth applied to action. Power is the gradient of the potential that generates forces moving the system toward equilibrium or transformation. Divine Power is the inexhaustible source energy sustaining all field dynamics.

Peace (Shalom) is the equilibrium state where $\partial V/\partial\phi = \partial V/\partial\chi = \partial V/\partial\eta = 0$ and the Hessian is positive definite (stable minimum). The eschatological Peace is the global minimum of the cosmic potential. Justice is a derived field—Goodness in social ordering. $J = G(\chi, \text{social coordinates})$. Justice inherits its normativity from Goodness but specifies it for relational contexts.

Part III: Relational Geometry and Distortion

6. The Primary Triad as Coordinate Axes

Truth, Goodness, and Beauty function as three orthogonal axes of the transcendental manifold. Each point (ϕ, χ, η) represents a possible configuration of transcendental values. The coupling parameters determine how changes along one axis influence the others. Love smooths the Truth-gradient, preventing discontinuities that would wound rather than heal. Truth spoken without love becomes harsh (1 Cor 13:1–3). Holiness constrains Power, ensuring it serves divine

purposes. Wisdom provides the metric on the freedom manifold that distinguishes liberating paths from enslaving ones.

7. Distortion Manifolds: When Transcendentals Misalign

Truth without Goodness produces cruel accuracy, weaponized facts, and scientific hubris. Goodness without Truth produces sentimental moralism and naive enabling. Beauty without Goodness produces aesthetic decadence, seductive evil, and beautiful lies. Power without Holiness produces tyranny, abuse, and corruption. Freedom without Wisdom produces license, chaos, self-destruction, and addiction. Justice without Mercy produces legalism, vengeance, and crushing condemnation. These correspond to movement away from the equilibrium submanifold toward unstable regions of configuration space.

Part IV: Christological and Trinitarian Integration

8. Christ as Incarnate Field Convergence

Jesus Christ is the point in configuration space where all transcendentals achieve their maximum values simultaneously—the global maximum of the combined field Lagrangian. “I am the Way, the Truth, and the Life” (John 14:6) maps to Truth-field and Truth-Goodness coupling. “I am the Light of the world” (John 8:12) maps to the gauge field revealing all transcendentals. “We beheld his glory” (John 1:14) maps to the Glory attractor in visible, historical form. “In him all things hold together” (Colossians 1:17) maps to the Unity principle. The incarnation represents the injection of this optimal configuration into the distorted field structure of fallen creation, initiating restoration dynamics.

9. Trinitarian Structure and Field Dynamics

The Father corresponds to the background Being that makes all fields possible—the vacuum state from which all excitations emerge, the origin of the coordinate system, the ground of the manifold. The Son is the Logos—the rational principle in whom all transcendentals are ordered and unified, the point of maximum field intensity, the location where the transcendental manifold achieves its highest curvature toward the Good. The Spirit corresponds to the gauge field enabling transport across the manifold—the Light that reveals, the Power that enables, the Love that binds. The Spirit moves creatures through configuration space toward the Glory attractor. The perichoretic unity of the Trinity models the ideal configuration: three distinct “locations” in transcendental space constituting one undivided Being.

10. The Economy of Salvation as Field Dynamics

Creation: The Father generates the transcendental manifold through the Son, with the Spirit hovering over emerging configuration space. Fall: Field configuration distorted by sin; coupling constants damaged; Truth, Goodness, and Beauty no longer cohere properly. Incarnation: Optimal field configuration enters history in Christ. Atonement: The Cross is the critical point where Justice and Mercy are maximized simultaneously. Resurrection: New creation begins—a new ground state for restored field dynamics. Pentecost: The Spirit poured out as the dynamic medium enabling movement toward the Glory attractor. Sanctification: Individual and corporate movement through configuration space toward Christlikeness. Consummation: All creation reaches the Glory attractor—stable maximum of all transcendentals in perfect Unity.

Part V: Formational Dynamics

11. Domain Mapping

The cognitive domain maps to Truth, Wisdom, and Light—the formation goal of a renewed mind (Romans 12:2), cultivated through study, meditation, and teaching. The affective domain maps to Beauty, Love, and Peace—the formation goal of ordered desires (Psalm 37:4), cultivated through worship, art, and contemplation. The volitional domain maps to Goodness, Justice, and Power—the formation goal of a sanctified will (Phil 2:13), cultivated through obedience, service, and mission.

12. The Dynamics of Sanctification

The process unfolds as: (1) Initial Illumination: Light reveals current field configuration (conviction of sin). (2) Truth Acquisition: Cognitive domain receives Truth input, updating the ϕ -field (renewal of mind). (3) Affective Reordering: Beauty draws desire toward proper objects (worship—beholding glory to become glorious, 2 Cor 3:18). (4) Volitional Alignment: Goodness informs choice, Power enables, Holiness constrains. (5) Integration through Love: Love binds developing fields, ensuring coherent growth. (6) Asymptotic Approach to Glory: Entire configuration moves toward the fixed point of complete transformation.

13. Practices as Field Interventions

Scripture study provides direct Truth-field input and couples with Wisdom when applied. Prayer opens channels to the Power source, aligns will with Goodness, and cultivates Peace. Worship is a primary Beauty-field intervention, beholding Glory for transformation. Fasting breaks attachment to lower attractors, creating space for higher configuration. Service exercises the Goodness-field in social contexts, developing Justice and Love. Confession confronts Truth about current configuration and invokes Mercy within Justice. Contemplation rests in Peace equilibrium, opens perception to Light, and deepens Unity. Suffering exposes field distortions,

drives toward Holiness, and develops character through resistance training in transcendental space.

Part VI: Scale Invariance and Nested Application

14. Scale-Invariant Lagrangian Structure

TFT's field equations apply at multiple scales because the Lagrangian structure is scale-invariant. The same Truth-Goodness-Beauty dynamics govern individuals, small groups, congregations, denominations, and the universal church. At the individual level, fields represent personal internalization of Truth, Goodness, and Beauty. At the group level, the group develops its own field configuration distinct from the sum of individual fields—collective coupling vs. individual coupling. At the congregational level, the institutional culture functions as the background manifold on which individual and group field dynamics evolve. At the denominational level, the denomination's institutional culture forms the next background manifold—the curvature of space within which all congregational, group, and individual field dynamics unfold. At the universal-church level, the outermost manifold is constituted by the church's catholic wholeness—the extent to which all traditions contribute their distinctive field strengths to the total configuration. When this outermost manifold is fractured by schism, every interior scale inherits the distortion.

15. Musical Analogy for Non-Technical Audiences

Imagine the universe is not fundamentally made of particles and forces but of music. Truth is Pitch—the basic frequency of the note. A note is either in tune or out of tune. Truth is the baseline structure of reality, the fundamental frequency of the universe. Goodness is

Harmony—the way different notes interact. Some chords feel stable, open, or pleasant. Goodness is the relational ordering among notes—how they serve or conflict with each other. Beauty is Rhythm/Timbre—the texture, timing, and quality of sound. Beauty is the aesthetic pattern that emerges when Truth and Goodness are working well together. The coupling parameters: α is how pitch influences harmony, β is how pitch influences timbre, γ is how harmony influences rhythm. When all three are well-coupled, you get a symphony. When decoupled, cacophony.

Soli Deo Gloria

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